

SAINT OF THE DAY

January 24, 2015

The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahido Church has been honoring both indigenous and foreign saints and martyrs dedicating a specific day to them throughout the year. Some of the saints were well known and celebrated in a very colorful feast, while others remembered in a daily readings of their biography, struggle with the pagans for the sake of Christ in order to understand the sacrifices done by them and inspire faithful to lead a spiritual life.

On the 16th of every Ethiopian Month, the church dedicated the feast of Kidane Mihret (ክዳኔ ማርያም), 'covenant of mercy' that refers to God's promise to St. Mary. every day of the year the church remembers at least one or two saints on the date of his or her death, or birth. Among these one of the saints who remembered on this day (January 24) is recorded in the book of Synaxarium as follows:

On this day Saint Philotheus, which name being interpreted is "lover of God," became a martyr. This saint was a man of Antioch, and his parents worshipped a bull which was called "Maraged." And they fed the bull on fine flour, which was boiled and mixed with fat, and seed-oil, and the honey of bees, and they anointed him with scented unguents thrice daily, and gave him wine and seed-oil to drink; and they built one house for him to live in during the winter and another for the summer. And they placed a collar of gold round his neck, and rings of gold on his fore legs and hind legs.

Now this saint was of very goodly appearance. And when he was ten years old his parents talked to him, and told him that he must worship the bull, but he would neither listen to their words nor do this thing, and because of their love for him, and because they did not wish to annoy him, they let him alone. Now Saint Philotheus did not know Christ, and he thought that the sun was God. And he stood up before the sun, saying, "I beseech thee, O sun, if thou art God, to tell me so"; and a voice came unto him from above, saying, "I am not God, but I am the servant and messenger of God Whom thou knowest, and thy blood shall be shed for the Name of God—Glory be to Him!"

And when God saw the integrity of heart of the boy Philotheus, He sent His angel to him at that moment, and the angel informed him about the mystery of God, and opened his heart so that he might understand what he said unto him; and when he had told him everything, beginning with the creation of the world, and ending with the Incarnation of our Lord Christ, the heart of the boy rejoiced and his spirit was glad. From that day he fasted, and prayed many prayers frequently, and he ate bread and salt only, and he gave alms to the poor and needy. And when a year had passed his parents determined to give a feast to his friends and companions, and they required of their son to offer incense in honor of the bull, before they ate and drank.

And the boy Philotheus stood up before the bull, and said unto him, "Is it true that thou art a god whom men worship?" And a voice came forth from the bull which said, "I am not a god, but Satan hath entered my heart and I have become a deceiver of men." Then the bull rose up and attacked the parents of the saint, and he gored them with his horns, and killed them. And the saint commanded his slaves to kill the bull [and they did so], and they burnt him in the fire, and scattered [his ashes] to the winds. And the parents of the saint were lying there dead, and God gave grace to Saint Philotheus, and he prayed over them, and their souls returned to them, and

they rose up straightway and told him how they had seen the punishments which were [inflicted] in Sheol. And after this Saint Philotheus and his parents were baptized with Christian baptism in the Name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Ghost.

And God gave him grace and power and he healed many sick folk by his prayer. And the report of him reached Diocletian the emperor, who sent and had him brought to him. And he said unto Saint Philotheus, "Cast incense to Apollo"; and he promised to give him many things if he would do so; and the saint rejected his promised things and his words. And the emperor commanded the soldiers to punish him with every kind of torture, [and they did so].

They first beat him with whips, and then they laid stones on his belly, and they did everything they could; but he was strong in the strength of God our Lord Jesus Christ. And he cursed the infidel emperor, and his unclean gods, until they smote him on the mouth, and cut out his tongue and broke his teeth; and when they had done all these things to him he would not hearken to the voice of the emperor. Then the emperor began to persuade him, and to use words of blandishment and flattery to him, but Saint Philotheus laughed at him, and promised that he would worship that idol; and the emperor rejoiced at this and imagined that he would really do so.

And he commanded his servants to bring Apollo, and the men and priests of the idols, and a herald went through the city who cried out, saying, "Come, O all ye people, so that ye may see Philotheus worshipping Apollo": and all the people gathered together about the tribune. And as they were bringing the idols along the road, Saint Philotheus asked our Lord Christ that the earth might open her mouth, and swallow up the idols and their priests. And straightway the earth opened her mouth and swallowed up the idols and their priests, and there was a great outcry round about; and when the people saw this, many of them believed on our Lord Christ. And the emperor was wroth, and he commanded the soldiers to cut off the heads of them all with the sword, [and they did so,] and they received the crown of martyrdom in the kingdom of the heavens, and entered into life everlasting. As for Saint Philotheus, when the emperor was tired of torturing him he commanded them to cut off his head with the sword, and he received the crown of martyrdom in the kingdom of the heavens.